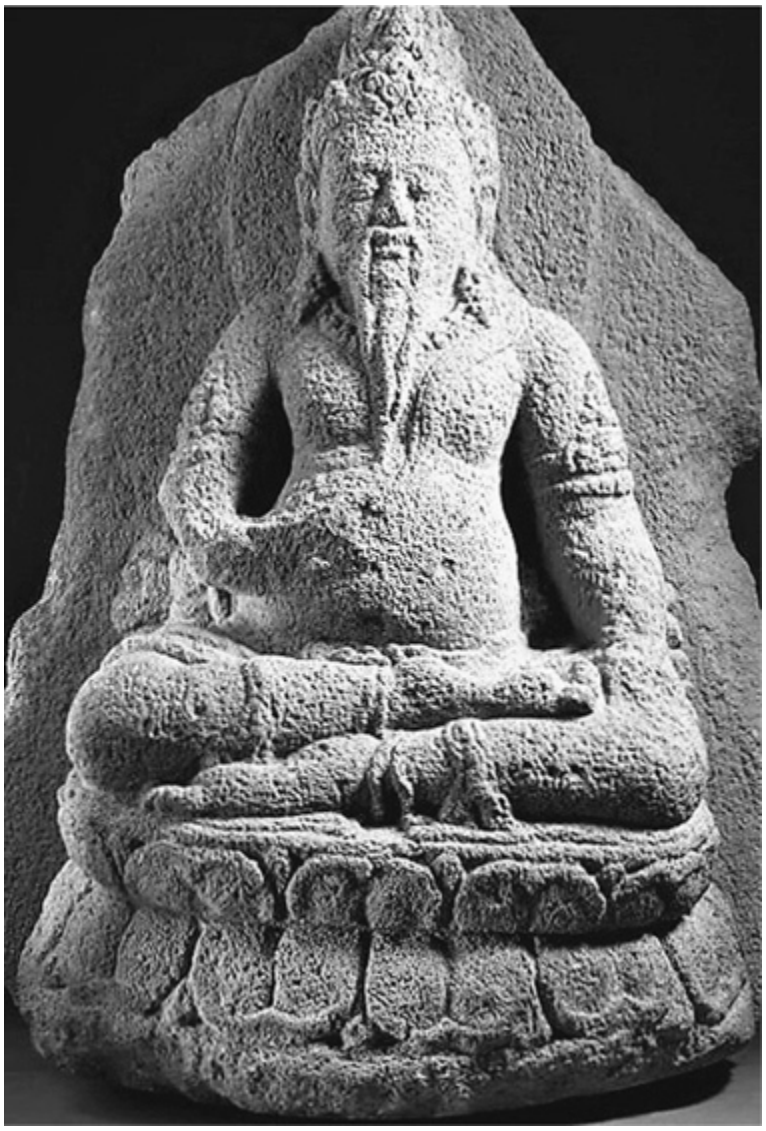


The pot-bellied dwarf-like sage known to some as Agastya, bringer of Sanskrit and Vedic culture to the South, and to others as Agathya, father of the Tamil language and Tamil culture. This tenth-century carving in volcanic tufa comes from central Java, where the cult of Agastya became widespread following the Chola expansion into South East Asia.

In sum, Agathya is *Tamilakam's* founding father. He is also a devotee of Lord Vishnu's great rival, Lord Shiva, which makes him a Shaiva or Shaivite.

So which is the 'real' rishi? The Sanskrit Agastya or the Tamil Agathya?

The oldest surviving grammar of the Tamil language is the *Tolkappiyam*, or 'ancient literature', a work that is regarded